Grant Sample 1: Federal / State Formula & Planning Grant

Project: Rural & Statewide Youth Transition AmeriCorps Planning Initiative
Funding Mechanism: AmeriCorps State & National Formula Planning Grant (State Service Commission)
Request Scale: $75,000 – $100,000 Planning Grant
Author: Brandon Hinrichs

---

1. Executive Summary

The applicant organization proposes to develop an AmeriCorps program serving rural and statewide communities across Nebraska, with an initial planning cohort of AmeriCorps members deployed to provide structured mentorship, life-skills coaching, and educational navigation for transition-age youth in foster care and community-based support systems. The 12-month planning grant establishes programmatic benchmarks, community advisory committees, member recruitment pathways, and supervisory ratios ensuring evidence-based delivery.

---

2. Statement of Need

Youth transitioning out of foster care and those living in rural agricultural communities face compound structural hurdles: 1. **Geographic Isolation:** Rural counties experience severe provider shortages in licensed behavioral health and youth transit. 2. **Linguistic and Cultural Barriers:** The region's Hispanic and Latino population represents the fastest-growing demographic (over 12% statewide and growing rapidly in rural processing hubs), yet bilingual service navigators remain scarce. 3. **Cliff Effect in Aging Out:** Without structured coaching, youth transitioning out of state care experience disproportionate rates of homelessness, food insecurity, and disconnection from post-secondary education within 18 months of exit.

---

3. Program Design & Planning Timeline

The planning period operates across structured multi-stage execution phases:

- **Months 1–2 (Kickoff & Governance):** Project kickoff; convene a multi-sector Planning Advisory Council including child welfare leaders, youth alumni, rural school liaisons, and bilingual specialists. Finalize charter and baseline assessment rubrics.

- **Months 3–5 (Community Needs & Stakeholder Mapping):** Administer rural needs assessments across partner counties; map existing service gaps in youth housing, employment readiness, and crisis intervention.
- **Months 6–8 (Member Service Design & Curriculum Alignment):** Define member position descriptions, service hour verification protocols, performance metrics, and compliance with prohibited activity standards. Establish member training modules in trauma-informed care and cross-cultural communication.
- **Months 9–10 (Host Site Agreements & Supervisory Protocols):** Negotiate formal Memorandums of Understanding (MOUs) with rural service hubs; build member supervisory frameworks ensuring 1:8 supervisory ratios.
- **Months 11–12 (Operational Application Build):** Consolidate data into the final 3-year AmeriCorps Operational Grant application, including multi-year matching schedules and longitudinal tracking models.

---

4. Organizational Capability & Compliance

The applicant organization maintains an active 501(c)(3) structure with extensive experience managing state-contracted human services, foster care training, and transitional living operations. Internal fiscal systems enforce fund accounting separation, preventing commingling of state, federal, and private philanthropic allocations. Member tracking incorporates automated timekeeping and criminal history background check (NSCHC) compliance pipelines.

---

5. Cost-Effectiveness & Budget Narrative (Sanitized Summary)

The planning grant budget reflects lean, direct operational investments: - **Personnel & Planning Leadership:** Part-time Planning Coordinator (0.25 FTE) dedicated to advisory coordination and statutory compliance. - **Fringe & Benefits:** Standard statutory payroll allocations (FICA, SUTA, workers' comp). - **Travel & Community Convenings:** Mileage allocated for rural county stakeholder listening sessions and state commission planning institutes. - **Supplies & Evaluation Tools:** Survey administration software, stakeholder materials, and community reporting briefs. - **Non-Federal Matching Share:** Local cash match and in-kind administrative contribution meeting state commission statutory ratios.